

The **Bhagavad Gita** (/ˈbʌɡəvəd ˈɡɪtɑː/;^[*] Sanskrit: भगवद्गीता, IPA: [ˈbʱəɡɐʋəd̪ ˈɡɪt̪aː], *romanized:* *bhagavad-gītā*, *lit.* 'God's song'),^[a] often referred to as the **Gita** (IAST: *Gītā*), is a Hindu scripture, likely composed in the second or first century BCE,^[7] which forms part of the epic poem *Mahabharata*. The Gita is a synthesis of various strands of Indian religious thought, including the Vedic concept of *dharma* (duty, rightful action); Sankhya-based *yoga* and *jñāna* (knowledge); and *bhakti* (devotion).^{[8][b]} Among the Hindu traditions, the Gita holds a unique pan-Hindu influence as the most prominent sacred text and is a central text in the Vedanta and Vaishnava traditions.

While traditionally attributed to the sage Veda Vyasa, the Gita is historiographically regarded as a composite work by multiple authors.^{[9][10][11]} Incorporating teachings from the Upanishads and the samkhya yoga philosophy, the Gita is set in a framework of dialogue between the Pandava prince Arjuna and his charioteer guide Krishna, an *avatar* of Vishnu, at the onset of the Kurukshetra War.^[6]

While the Gita praises the benefits of yoga^{[12][13]} in releasing man's inner essence from the bounds of desire and the wheel of rebirth,^[6] the text stresses the Brahmanic idea of living according to one's duty or *dharma*, in contrast to the ascetic ideal of seeking liberation by avoiding all *karma*.^[12] Facing the perils of war, Arjuna hesitates to perform his duty (*dharma*) as a warrior. Krishna persuades him to commence in battle, arguing that while following one's dharma, one should not consider oneself to be the agent of action, but attribute all of one's actions to God (*bhakti*).^{[14][15]}

Numerous classical and modern thinkers have written commentaries on the Gita with differing views on its essence, and the relation between the individual self (*jivatman*) and the supreme self (Atman/Brahman) or God (Krishna).^{[16][c]} The Krishna-Arjuna dialogue has been construed as a metaphor for an immortal dialogue between the individual and the supreme self.^[d] The Gita's setting in a battlefield has been interpreted by many scholars as an allegory for the struggles and vagaries of human life.^[17]